

Strategy Knotworking

Liberating Structures Slowdown Series | April, May & June 2026

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A true Strategy Knotworking **Slow**down might look like several days, several months, or even several years...

Agenda Sequence

Session 1

Arriving & Settling

Knot By-the-Book (Rapid Writing)

Strategy Knotworking Background

Purpose

Baseline

Context

Conclusion

Session 2

Arriving & Settling

Recap Session 1

Challenge

Ambition

Action & Evaluation

Design Options

Conclusion

Finding a Focus

Option 1: A current or upcoming project that you want to generate a strategy for

Option 2: A change or transition you are anticipating

Option 3: If you have a business, practice, organization, or community you are part of and want to elaborate on the strategy for it, you can pick that, too

Narrow in on something tangible.

Trio Conversations

In small groups, share the project, organization, or change you have chosen and why that feels significant or important to focus on.

Strategy Knotworking

Purpose: Answer Six Questions Together to Develop
Strategy Everyone Owns

Purposes

In Strategy Knotworking (SKW), participants answer six questions to develop a strategic initiative in a complex context. It is designed to engage everyone who will execute the strategy in its development, building shared ownership of higher-order goals and capacity to respond to uncertainty. SKW reinforces the LS principle *Amplify Freedom and Responsibility*.

By-the-Book Sequence of Steps

- **Structuring Invitation:** "Today we are a group of intrepid explorers planning a route for our adventures over the next 5-10 years. We will develop our strategic plan by mapping our purpose, context, challenges, current state, and next steps in quick iterative cycles and collecting our insights as we go."
- **Sequence of Steps and Time Allocation:** (~6 hours, all at once or split over up to 4 days)
 - **Introduction:** Share the structuring invitation. Explain the process: The group will explore six questions and capture results on the SKW template, using sticky notes so they can be updated and moved around. At the end, the group will be able to tell the strategy story by talking through the six questions. Display Figure 5.51 and hand out copies. [Participants draw their own copy.] (3 min)
 - **Question 1: Purpose:** Ask: What is the fundamental justification and deepest need for our work? Define the group's purpose by following these steps:
 - **Paired Interviews:** First alone, then in pairs [alone only], participants reflect on the question "Why does our work truly matter, both to us and to the wider world?" (10 min F2F, 5 min online)
 - **Draft Purpose.** Pairs join to form quartets [breakouts of 3] and share their ideas, stories, and perspectives for 10 minutes. Next, they draft a purpose statement on their template and prepare to share their purpose drafts with the whole group. [Broadcast instructions to all groups. The host visits breakouts to check group dynamics and make sure they are on track.] (20 min)
 - **Sharing and Finalizing Draft Purposes.** Everyone returns to plenary. A few small groups share their ideas. Consolidate them into one purpose and write it on the shared SKW template. Have participants generate ideas about how they will know they are making progress on the purpose, using this format: "We are making progress on our purpose when (WHO) does (WHAT) and that creates (DESIRED OUTCOME)." (30 min)

By-the-Book Sequence of Steps

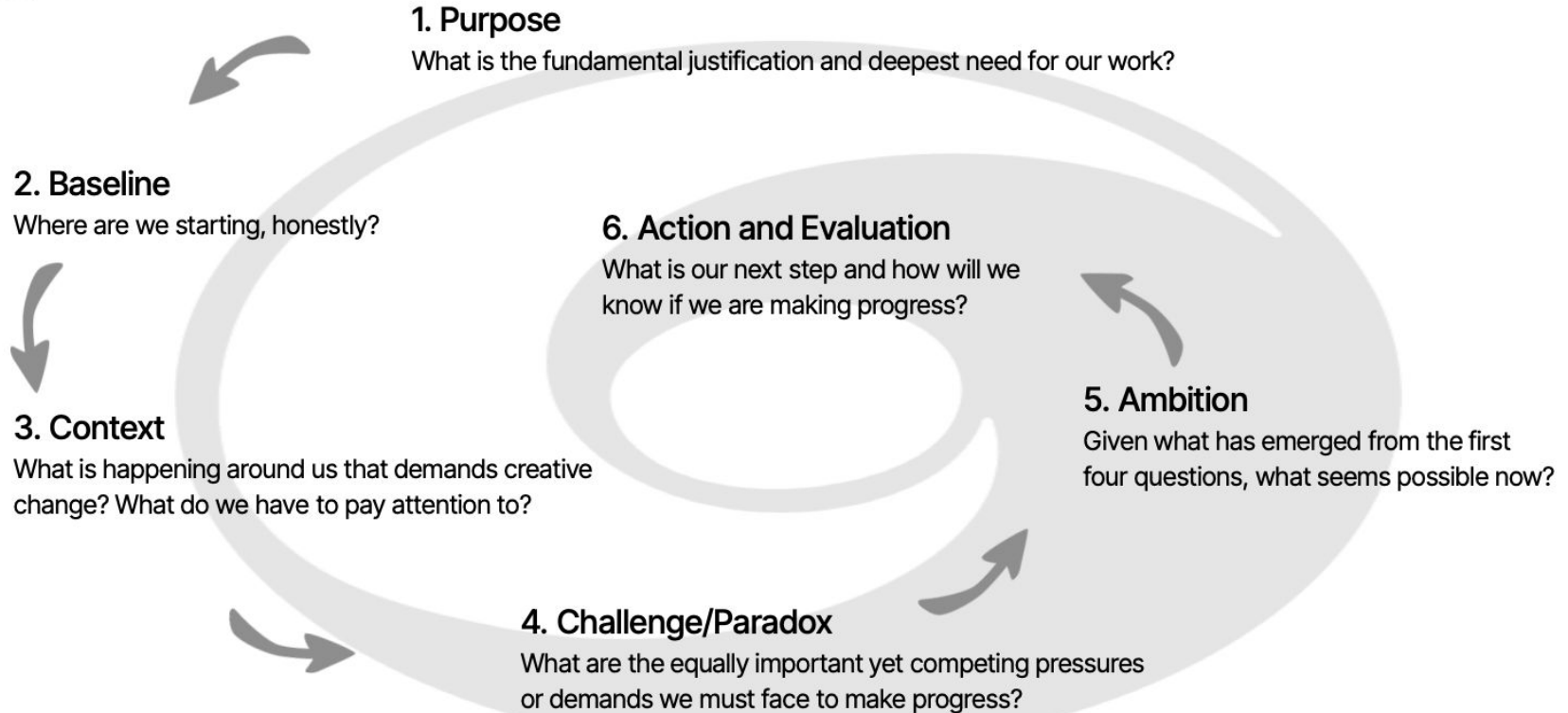
- **Question 2: Baseline:** Ask: **Where are we starting, honestly?** Use Ecocycle Planning to establish the baseline for existing capabilities, actions, and relationships. Place the Ecocycle at the center of the shared SKW template. Everyone can refer back to and refine the Ecocycle as they move through the other questions. (60 min)
- **Question 3: Context:** Ask: **What is happening around us that demands creative change?** What do we have to pay attention to? Use Critical Uncertainties to help the group see different futures unfolding, prepare for distributed action, and be resilient to disruptions. Everyone places the robust and hedging strategies they have identified on the shared SKW template. Everyone can refer back to it when they get to Question 5. (90 min)
- **Interlude and Break:** Explain the process: For each additional element, the group will break into small groups and then return to share discoveries and add them to the shared template. The process is not always linear, and the group may need to revisit and revise earlier steps, particularly Purpose, as they gain new insights. Everyone takes a quick break. (10-20 min)
- **Question 4: Challenge/Paradox:** Ask: What are the equally important yet competing pressures or demands we must face in order to make progress? Use Wicked Questions to identify paradoxical or competing pressures that need to be addressed simultaneously, or swap in another LS such as Creative Destruction. (30 min)
- **Question 5: Ambition:** Ask: Given what has emerged from the first four questions, what seems possible now? Follow these steps or use 25/10 Crowdsourcing or Future-Present to identify bold yet actionable ideas for next steps. (50 min total)
 - **Intro:** As a group, review everything captured in the SKW template. Ask: Do we need to adjust our purpose? What patterns do you notice that make a current strategy obsolete or open a new door? (10 min)
 - **Individual Reflection:** Participants list bold yet actionable next steps, which could be small or large. (10 min)
 - **Compare Ideas in Groups:** Participants form quartets to compare their ideas and select the best ideas to bring to the full group. (10 min)
 - **Share Ideas:** Everyone returns to plenary. A few small groups share their ideas. Add key options to the SKW template as a first draft of the group's potential strategy. (20 min)

By-the-Book Sequence of Steps

- **Question 6: Action & Evaluation:** Ask: What is our next step and how will we know if we are making progress? (60 min)
 - **Intro:** Invite the group to consider next steps and how they will know they are making progress on possibilities they have identified. (3 min)
 - **Share Ideas in Groups:** Participants return to the same groups from Question 5 and develop strategies and next steps. Ask: What limited number of strategies should we prioritize for immediate action? What are our next steps for each strategy? How will we know we are making progress with each strategy and ensure they serve our purpose? (20 min)
 - **Finalizing Ideas:** Everyone returns to plenary. A few groups share their ideas. Add key options to the SKW template to create the final draft of the group's strategy. As a group, discuss how the strategies will work together to amplify results. Use an Ecocycle template (Figure 5.46) to track and evaluate progress and a visual tracking tool like a kanban board to track timing and coordinate actions. (30 min)
- **Setting Future Milestones:** The group decides when to review and adjust the strategic plan. (5 min)



Strategy Knotworking (SKW) Template



Strategy Knotworking as an Umbrella

- Most often, Knotworking functions an umbrella, within which specific LS are nested.
- For example:
 - Purpose might be explored through the use of:
 - 9 Whys
 - Conversation Cafe
 - TRIZ
 - 1-2-4-All
 - Spiral Journal

And any number of other LS. The same goes for the other Knotworking lenses.

Strategy Knotworking as an Accordion Over Time

- Strategy Knotworking might take place over a year and a half, a day, 2 hours, three months...
 - Key contributors/ collaborators can facilitate interviews and/ or group discussions about any of the Knotworking lenses to bring into sensemaking conversations.
 - The Knotworking lenses can shape the design of a 2-day strategy retreat for a group.
 - The lenses and prompts can comprise writing exercises at a particular cadence over time, or just once.
 - A 1.5 year process can be designed around the lenses in a particular order and as phases, or iteratively over time, or a mix of both.

Strategy Knotworking as Attunement

- While Knotworking is often used to facilitate an organization's strategic planning process, there are two ways it acts as an attunement approach:
 - Using the Knotworking lenses on an ongoing basis with a group to check in on progress, supporting groups as they adapt to changes in the context.
 - Using the Knotworking lenses specifically within groups or as an individual to consider behavior, communications, awareness, process mindfulness to improve effectiveness.

We are going to modify the By-the-Book description today and do it first all-at-once as a writing practice and then take each element or lens one-at-a-time and use different LS to elaborate on them.

YxN Writing

Purpose: Rapidly Generate Material

Purposes

Why does our work truly matter, both to us and to the wider world?

What do I hope & believe this work makes possible?

The purpose of this work/ project/ organization/ effort is...

How do I/ we justify spending time and resources on this work?

If our work was obliterated tomorrow, what are the first pieces we'd bring back, and why?

Baselayers (The Current State)

What am I / are we actively doing, investing in, and spending time, energy, effort, and resources on?

Where am I / are we starting, honestly?

What are the assets & conditions we have that can carry us forward?

What is the current network of tight & loose connections that influence our work?

What does the web look like? Beyond individual talent, how are we generating social capital?

Contexts

What is happening around us that demands creative adaptation & change?

What are some of the uncertainties facing this work? What is hard to predict, control, anticipate, or influence?

What are people seeing, hearing, feeling, sensing, noticing, and observing about the internal & external environment we're operating within/across?

What are the weak & strong signals I/ we need to tune into?

What are the things that make you a little anxious, nervous, or would have a big impact on you? What are the things that you kind of just ignore because they are intimidating, difficult, or scary to confront?

Challenges

What are the paradoxical realities I/ we must work with in order to make progress?

What polarities make our work complex?

What is the nature of the challenges I/ we face and how might we respond?

What are some of the dynamics that make this difficult?

What are the obstacles and barriers I/ we face?

Ambitions

If I/ we make progress on this effort, what would that make possible?

What needs are we prepared to meet? What can we meaningfully include? What needs to be excluded?

Actions & Evaluation

What are we actually going to spend time & resources on? *What principles will guide our choices moving forward? What options can we see? How will we know we are making progress? What are we doing to move deliberately into the future?*

How are we cultivating adjacent possibilities/options that will enable us to respond more effectively in the future? ***How will we evaluate whatever develops?***

What do we need to stop doing that is no longer delivering value? *What operational structures, habits, and practices will support us along the way?*

What are the priorities?

Paired Narration

With a partner or in a trio, you'll each have time to narrate the strategy for your topic using the materials you generated. Trust your brain's ability to make sense of it in the moment. See how it feels to put all of the elements together in a coherent way.

You can also share your experience moving through these prompts in a sequence, and how you have responded to the writing process.

If people share strategies, take a few minutes to respond to one another's ideas and what has emerged.

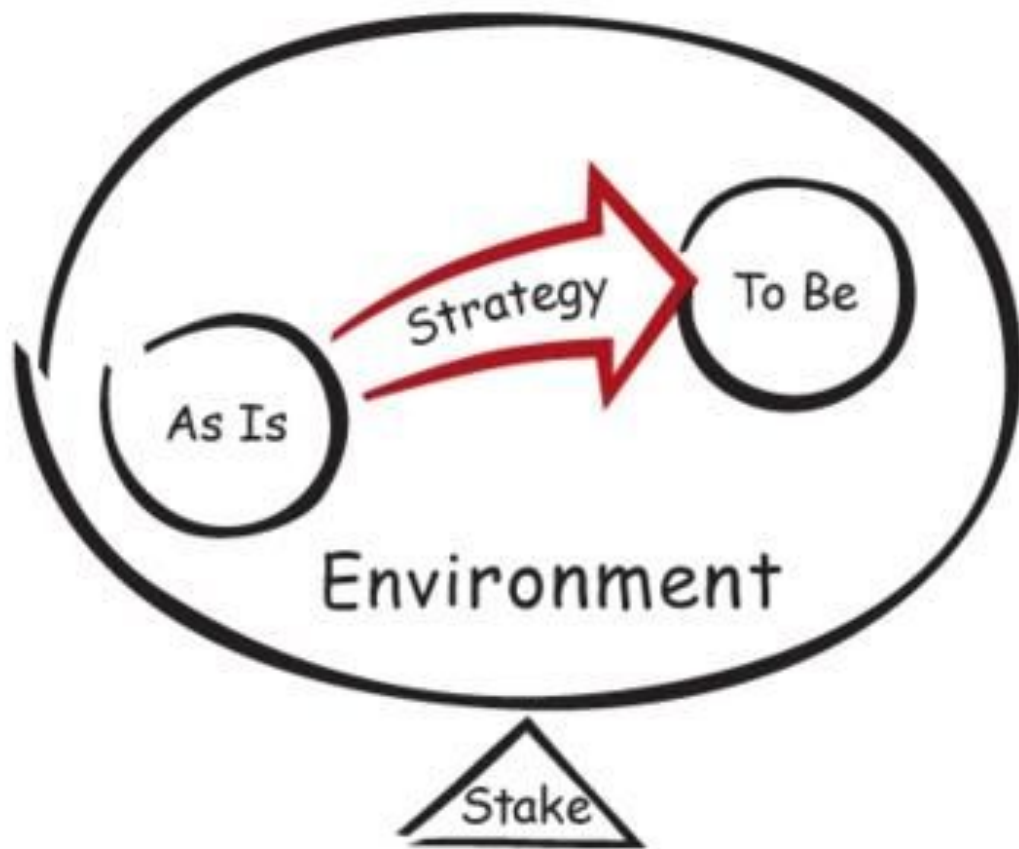


Phylogeny of Strategy Knotworking

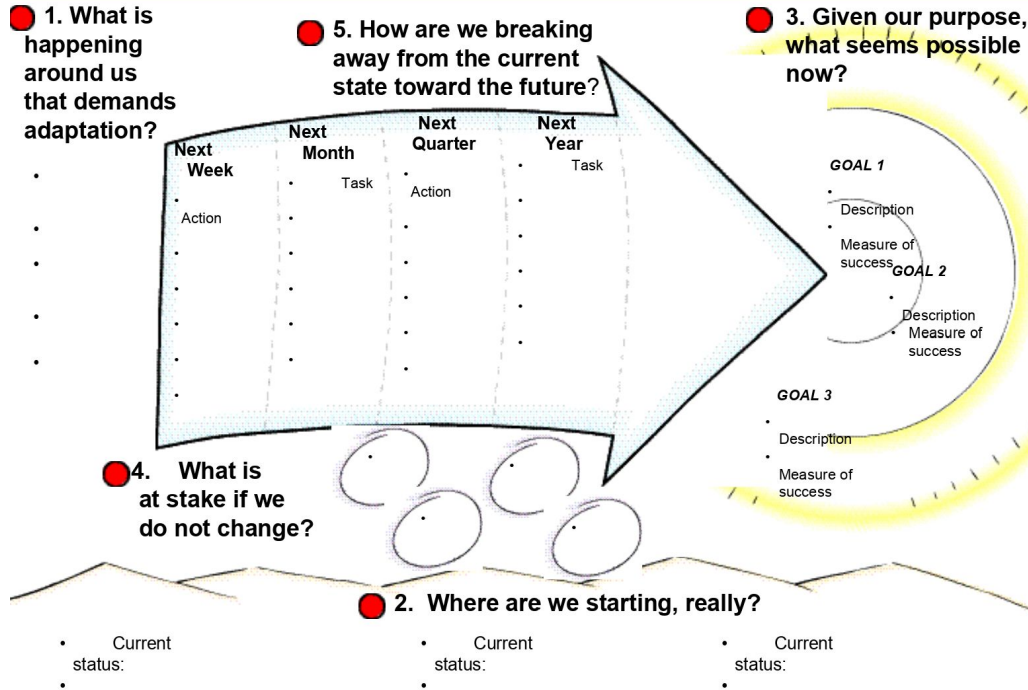
Walking Backwards through the (Incomplete) Developmental Story of SK



The Primes: Core Prime



Strategy Safari GAME PLAN



Strategy Safari (Mad Tea Party Sequence) and Celebrity Interview questions:
For strategy sessions, dig deeper into challenges by asking: What is happening around us that demands creative adaptation? What happens if we do nothing? Given our purpose, what seems possible now? If our current strategies were obliterated last night, what parts would you bring back today?

Strategy Safari

INCLUDING AND UNLEASHING EVERYONE

[Home](#)
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[Henri](#)
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Celebrity Interview

Reconnect the Experience of Leaders and Experts with People Closest to the Challenge at Hand (35-60 min.)

What is made possible? You can enable a large group of people to connect with a leader or an expert the celebrity, as a person and grasp the nuances of how that person is approaching a challenge. With a well-designed interview, you can turn what would otherwise be a passive, often boring presentation into a personal narrative that is entertaining, impacts valuable knowledge, and reveals the full range of rational, emotional, and ethical/moral dynamics at play. You can often turn the interview into an invitation to action, drawing out all the elements needed to spark the participant group's imagination and encourage cohesive action.

Five Structural Elements – Min Specs

1. Structuring Invitation

- Invite the celebrity to let go of his or her formal presentation or speech and answer the harder questions on everyone's mind in a casual "talk show" format.
- Invite group members to listen, see the person behind the celebrity, and write down questions with colleagues.

2. How Space is Arranged and Materials Needed

- Interviewer and celebrity in the front of the room where everyone can see and hear the interaction (lapel microphones, bar stools, or living-room furniture recommended).
- Unlimited number of people in a space where they can sit to view the interview and later form small groups (theater-style seating is OK).
- 3-by-5-inch cards to collect questions generated via 1-2-4.

3. How Participation is Distributed

- Part one, interview: everyone has an equal opportunity to listen.
- Part two, questions: everyone has an equal opportunity to engage with one another to formulate questions.

How Groups are Configured

- Whole group for interview.
- Individuals, pairs, small groups for 1-2-4 to generate questions.

Sequence of Steps and Time Allocation

- Interviewer welcomes and introduces the celebrity and topic to be discussed. 3 min.
- Interviewer asks questions that the audience would be expected to ask (both humor and gravity are appropriate). 15-20 min.
- Invite participants to generate additional questions in a 1-2-4 conversation and then on 3-by-5-inch cards. 5-10 min.
- Interviewer lifts the cards, looking for patterns and asking additional questions to the celebrity. 5-10 min.
- Interviewer makes closing comments, thanks the celebrity. 1 min.

WHY? Purposes

- Create or boost a connection between an expert or leader and an audience.
- Give substance and depth to a topic.
- Avoid boring lectures and PowerPoint presentations.
- Engage every individual in generating questions for further exploration.
- Shed light on the person behind the position or expertise.
- Bring big concepts to life with stories that come out in the interview.

Tips and Tricks

- A good sequence of starting questions is: "What first inspired you in this work? What challenges you in this work? What keeps you going in this work? What do you hope can happen for us in this work?"
- Give the questions to the celebrity in advance.
- If possible, send background materials to participants in advance.
- Do not allow the introduction to become a mini-lecture.
- Interview questions should not be trivial or easy to answer.
- Interviewer must ask repeatedly for stories and concrete details that illustrate concepts.
- Interviewer may ask the celebrity, "Why is ____ important to YOU (not the larger organization or system)?"

Riffs and Variations

- Have fun with riffs from the talk-show genre: channel Oprah, Stephen Colbert, or your favorite celebrity interviewer.
- The interviewer can conduct research in advance of the session, asking participants: "What do you want to know but would not dare to ask? What is the most important thing you want to know about this person or the work ahead?"
- Use a storytelling template to structure your interview (e.g., the Hero's Journey).
- For strategy sessions, dig deeper into challenges by asking: "What is happening around us that demands creative adaptation? What happens if we do nothing? Given our purpose, what seems possible now? If our current strategies were obliterated last night, what parts would you bring back today?"
- Use with virtual groups. Conduct the video/live interview while inviting all other participants to develop questions and comments in pairs or groups. Share the top questions via the chat function to "all" when the interview is complete.
- String together with User Experience Fitbow!, Open Space, DAO, and What I Need From You.

News and Events

What People Are Saying

Introduction

Food for Thought Blog

LS Menu

Field Stories

Topics

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Keith McCandless

Henri Lipmanowicz

User Resources

Field Stories

Overview

Individual Transformations

Business Turnaround: From Lagging To Leading

Superbug Prevention Plus Enduring Culture Change

Artful Passage of Senate Bill 29

Academic Leadership from the Inside Out

Liberalizing The Courts and Child Welfare Law

Army After-Action-Reviews as a Fitbow!

Inventing the Future of Healthcare

Mantra's Rehearsal for Real Life as a Nurse

Straight Up Business: Settling the Spiller

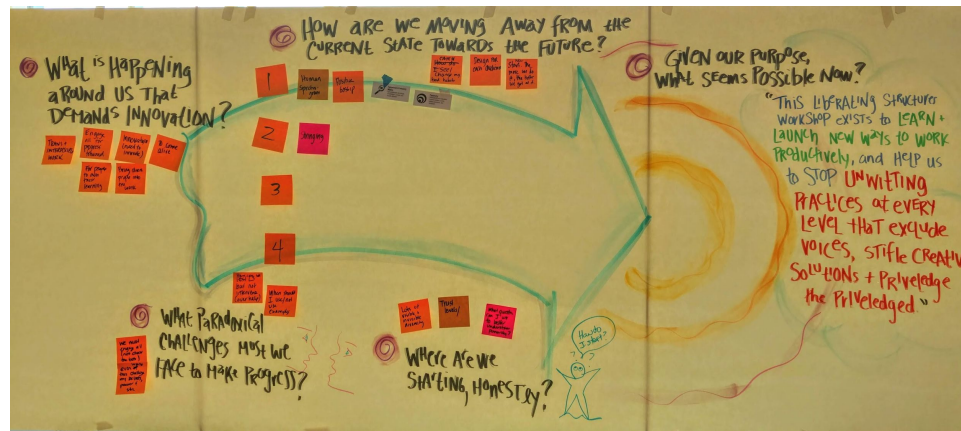
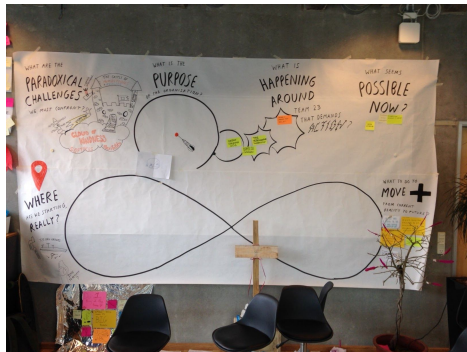
Getting Out of the Information IT Department

Innovating by Including and Unleashing Everyone

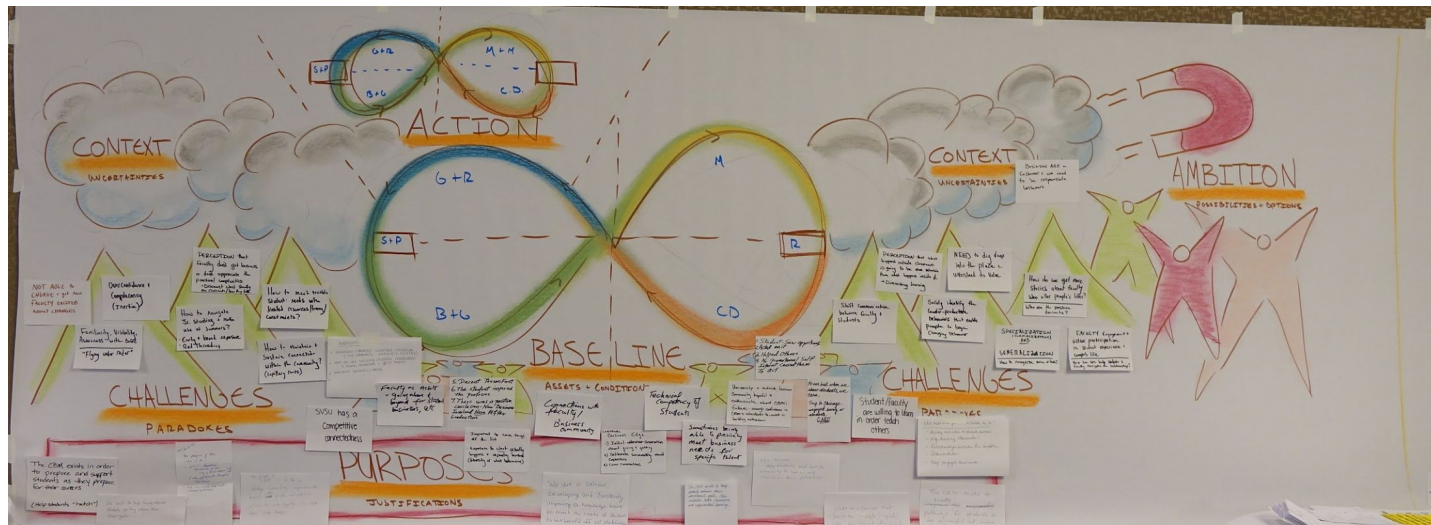
Novices to Expert Innovators in Biology

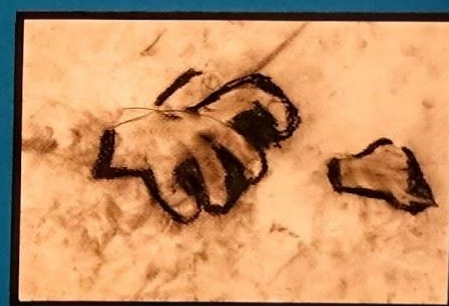
Inclusive High-Stakes Decision Making Made Easy

Search the website:



A visual template & recording document





Strategy Knotworking as a narrative owned and operated by everyone



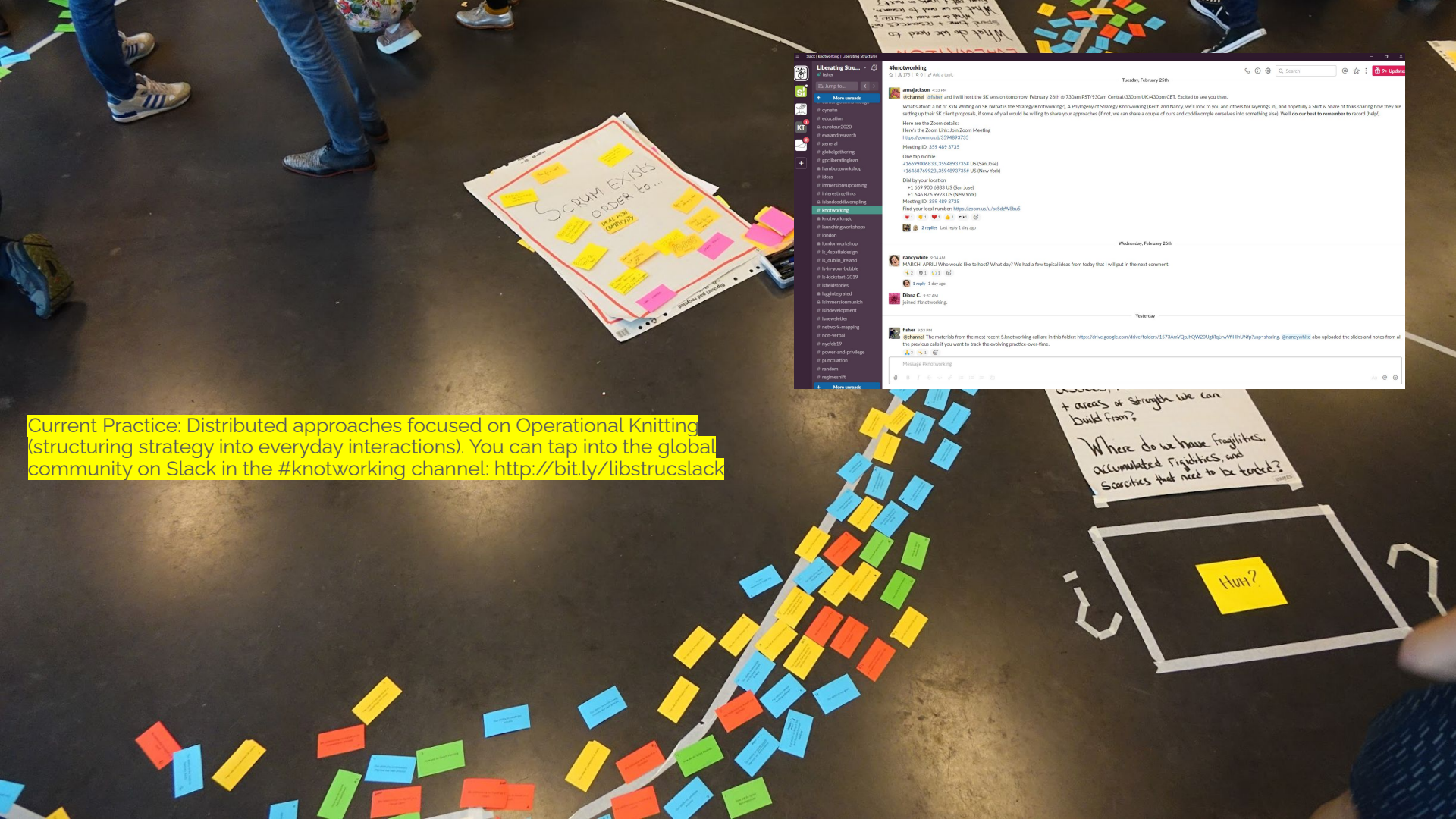


Strategy Knotworking gets a name! [~2018]



Writing & publishing about Sk:

- Nancy White's Blog Posts "[Adaptive Strategy Development](#)" & "[Facilitating Strategic Planning in Complex Contexts](#)"
- Keith & Johannes' Article "[Liberating Strategy: Putting surprise and serendipity to work](#)"



Current Practice: Distributed approaches focused on Operational Knitting (structuring strategy into everyday interactions). You can tap into the global community on Slack in the #knotworking channel: <http://bit.ly/libstrucslack>

Slack (knotworking) Libstruc Structures

Libstruc Structures
#knotworking

More unread

- #civnet
- #education
- #euro2020
- #evolutionresearch
- #general
- #globalgathering
- #gpcilustrations
- #hackinggovernance
- #ideas
- #internationalismcoming
- #interacting-into
- #knotworking
- #knotworkingworkshops
- #london
- #londonworkshop
- #n-digitalworkshop
- #n-dublin-ireland
- #in-your-bubble
- #knotwork-2019
- #knotworkstories
- #knotworkintegrated
- #knotworkcommunity
- #knotworksupport
- #knotworkletter
- #network-mapping
- #new-ventures
- #nycnet19
- #power-and-privilege
- #privatization
- #random
- #regimental

More unread

amjackson · 10:11 PM

@channel @faher and I will host the SK session tomorrow, February 26th @ 7:00am PST/9:00am Central/12:00pm UK/4:00pm CET. Excited to see you there.

What's also at stake is NKN Writing on SK. What is the Strategy Knotworking? A Philosophy of Strategy Knotworking (Math and Nancy, we'll look to you and others for inspirings) is, and hopefully a SHIT & Share of folks sharing how they are setting up their SK client proposals, if some of y'all would be willing to share your approaches (if not, we can share a couple of ours and codeword ourselves into something else). We'll do our best to remember to record (help).

Here are the Zoom details.

Here's the Zoom Link, join Zoom Meeting
<https://zoom.us/j/3594893755>

Meeting ID: 359 489 3755

One tap mobile

+1 669 900 6833 359 489 3755 US (San Jose)

+1 646 876 9123 359 489 3755 US (New York)

Call by your location

+1 669 900 6833 US (San Jose)

+1 646 876 9123 US (New York)

Meeting ID: 359 489 3755

Find your local number: <https://zoom.us/j/3594893755>

1 reply · 1 day ago

Wendnesday, February 26th

nancywhite · 10:11 AM

10:12 AM @channel Who would like to host? What day? We had a few topical ideas from today that I will put in the next comment.

1 reply · 1 day ago

Diana C · 10:17 AM

joined #knotworking

Yesterday

faher · 10:18 PM

@channel The materials from the most recent Sknotworking call are in this folder: <https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/15734mGqHq2204qH2uVHhRtUhp/usp=sharing>. @nancywhite also uploaded the slides and notes from all the previous calls if you want to track the evolving practice over time.

Message #knotworking

Purpose: 9 Whys

Sequence of Steps

1. Write down a few sentences about your project and why it is important to you and the wider community. What do you hope and believe it makes possible? You can start with what you already generated for the Purpose part of YxN.
2. Then, write down a few key items or elements related to your project. What is it? You can use the list you generated under Baselayer in YxN
3. In pairs, interview each other and ask why, why, why this project matters and why, why, why those key activities are important.
4. Share some observations with each other and then on your own write down a statement that describes the fundamental justification for spending time, energy, and resources on it.

Write down a statement that describes the fundamental justification for spending time, energy, and resources on the project

Baselayers: Ecocycle Planning

Sequence of Steps

1. Identify the set of things you want to map out and write them down in a numbered list. You should have a good start to this from your Baselayers list in YxN.
2. Start placing the items on an Ecocycle worksheet - you can draw this or use one of the slides below.
3. Step back and start making sense of what the Ecocycle reveals.

Incubation & Gestation
Exploration & dynamic rearrangement

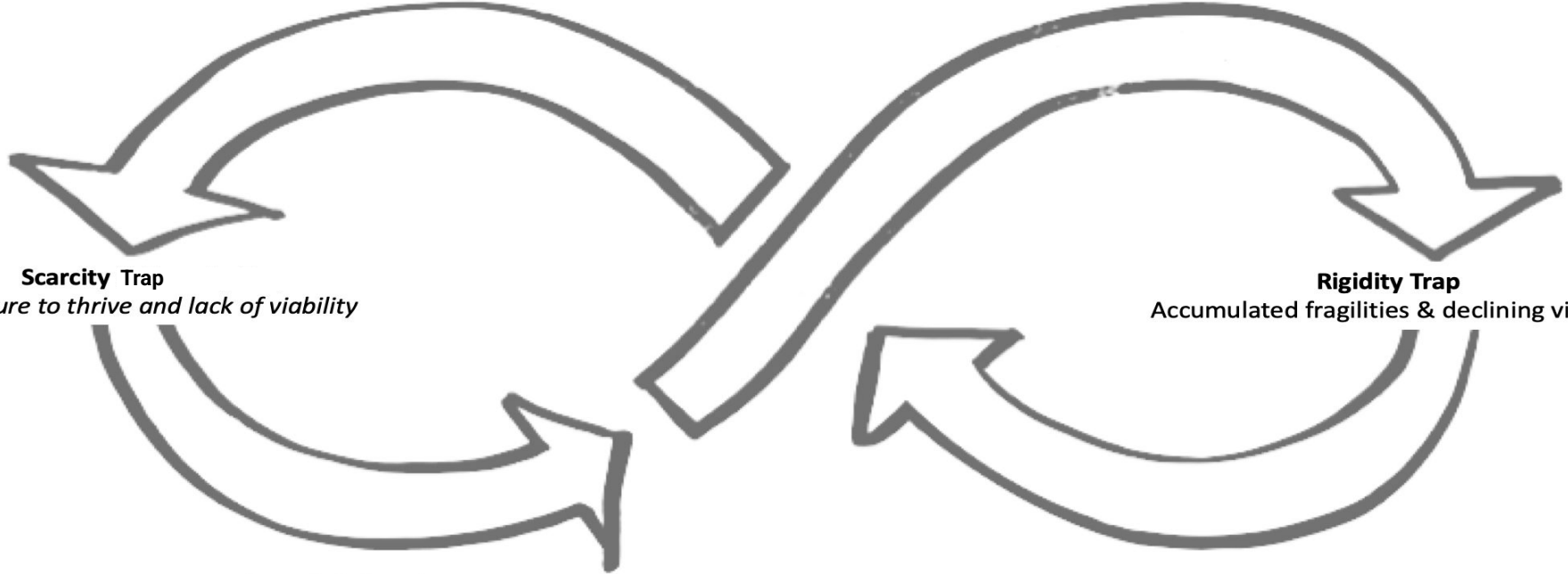
Maturity & Stability
Conserve and preserve what is reliable

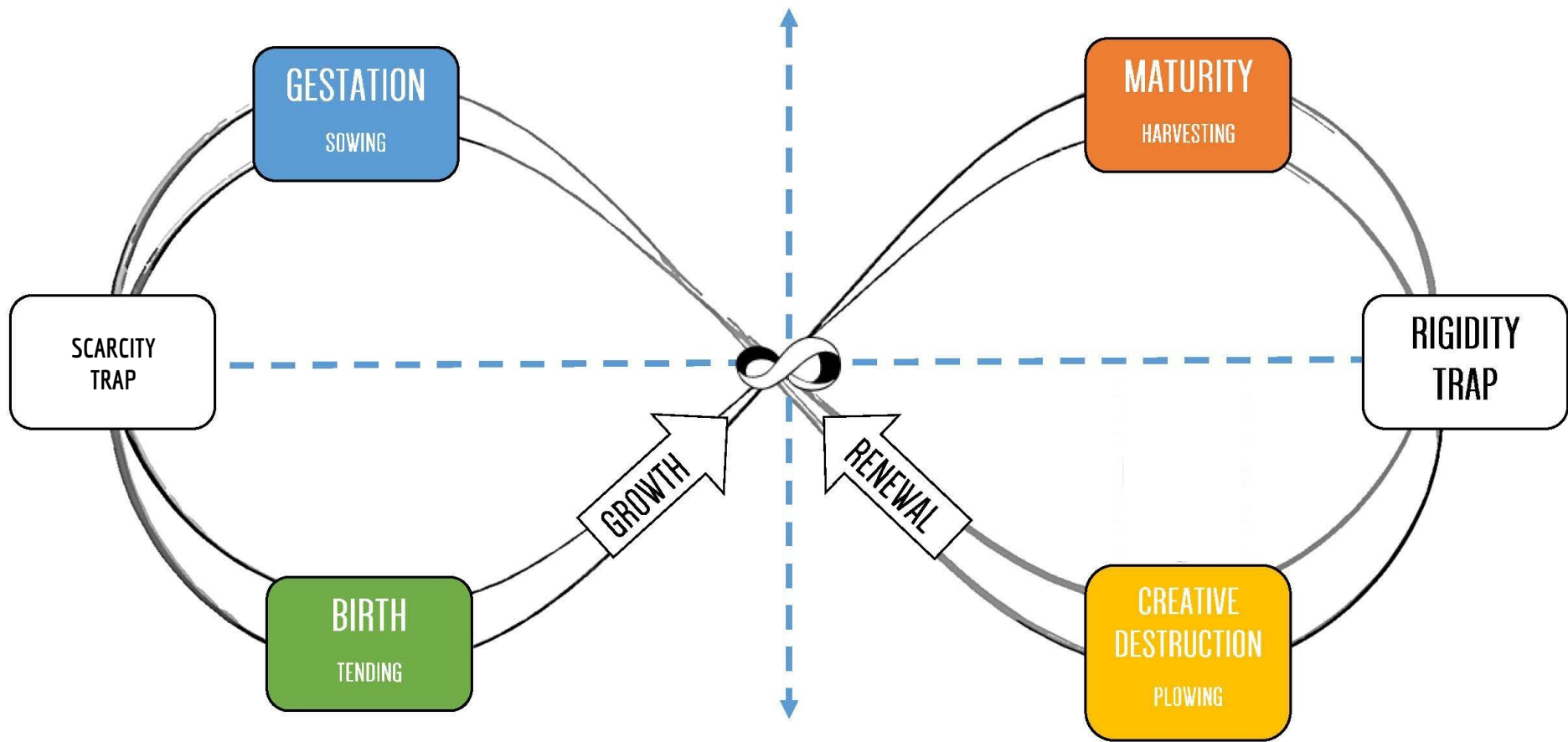
Scarcity Trap
Failure to thrive and lack of viability

Rigidity Trap
Accumulated fragilities & declining vitality

Growth & Development
Continuously discovering what works

Creative Destruction
Letting go, disintegration & renewal





*Draw an Ecocycle and start placing the items
you listed on it*

Incubation & Gestation
Exploration & dynamic rearrangement

Service A

Process B

Maturity & Stability
Conserve and preserve what is reliable

Relationship A

Relationship C

Process A

Rigidity trap
Accumulated fragilities & declining vitality

Service B

Relationship B

Creative Destruction
Letting go, disintegration & renewal

Growth & Development
Continuously discovering what works

Project A

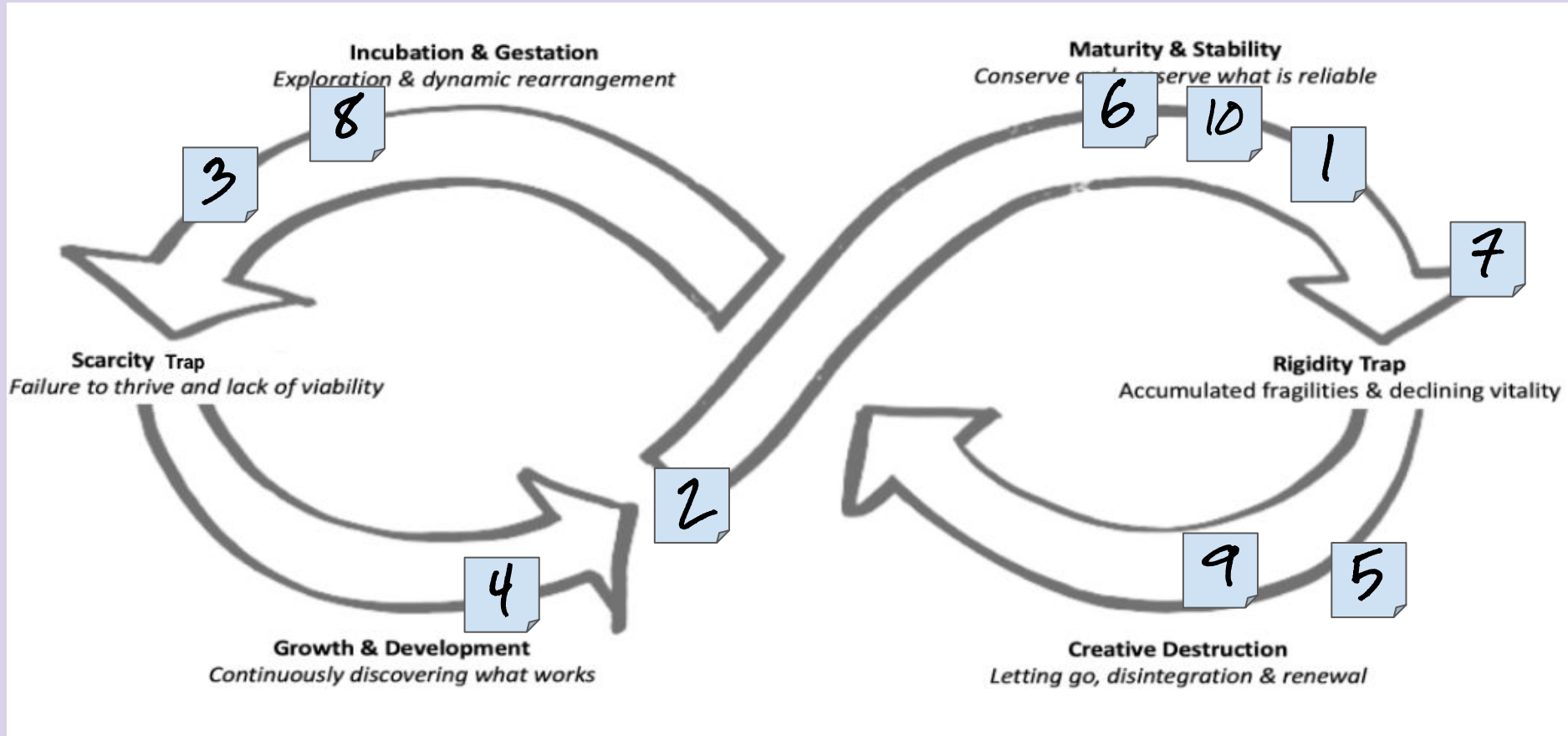
Project B

Relationship B

Failure to thrive and lack of viability

Once you have everything mapped, there are a bunch of sensemaking and action-oriented questions you can explore:

- *What do you notice about the distribution of activities across the Ecocycle? How does it make you feel to look at everything this way?*
- *Are there any placements that surprise you?*
- *What barriers or opportunities do you see given where things are?*
- *If you zoom in on a specific item, what is necessary for it to move further along? What do you need from others and yourself? What or who is helping it along and holding it back?*



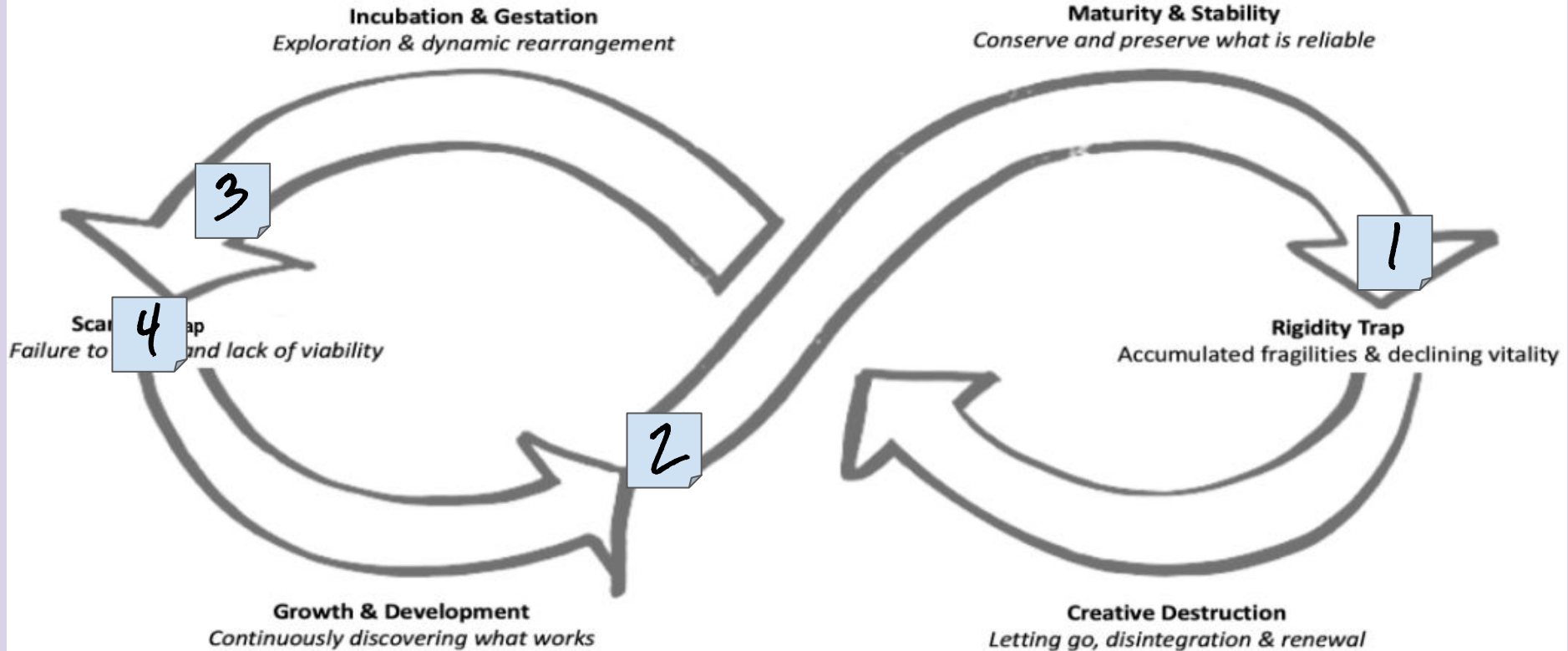
5 6 7 8 9 10

Name: Håkon

1: Ai policy

2+3: where people are at

4: AI use case application form



6

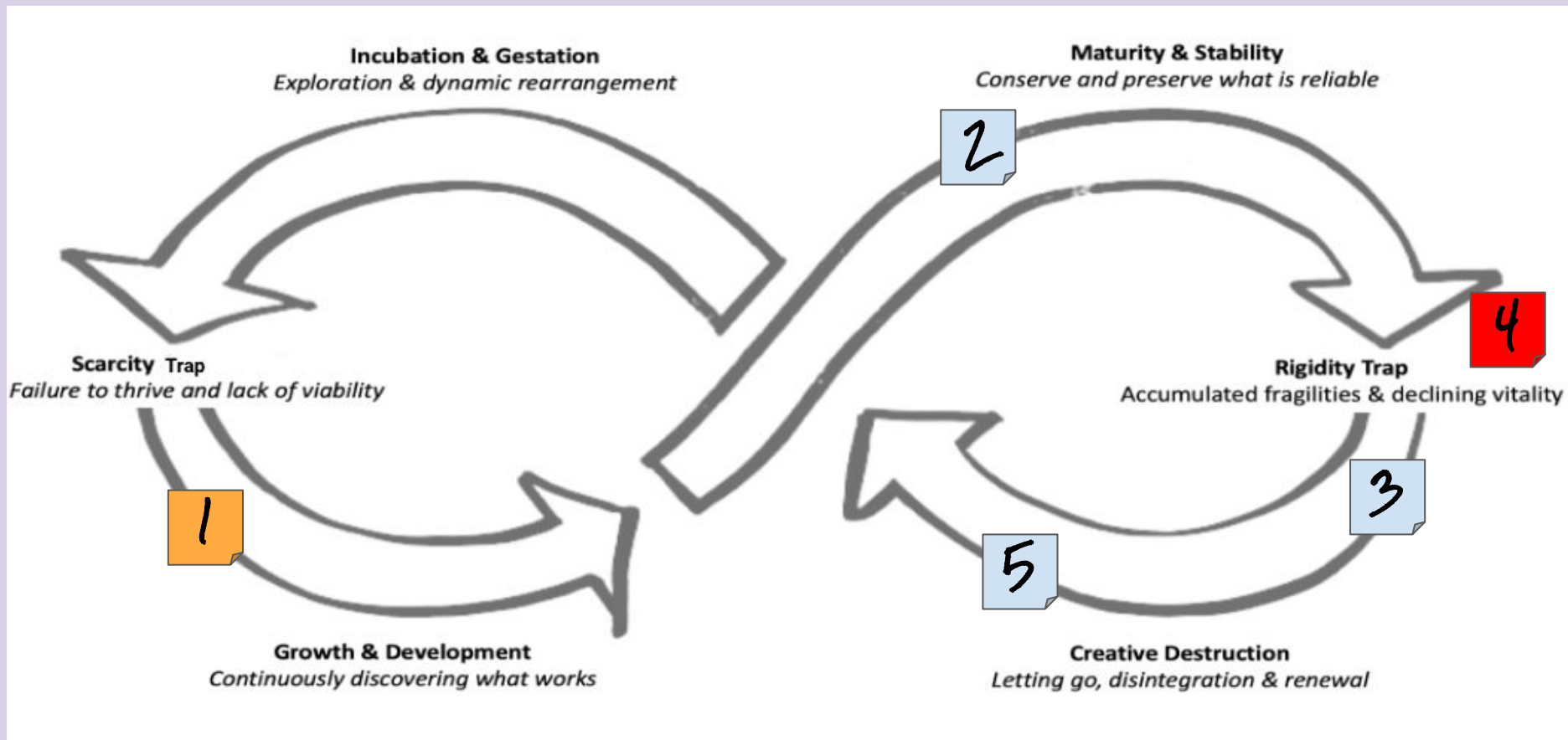
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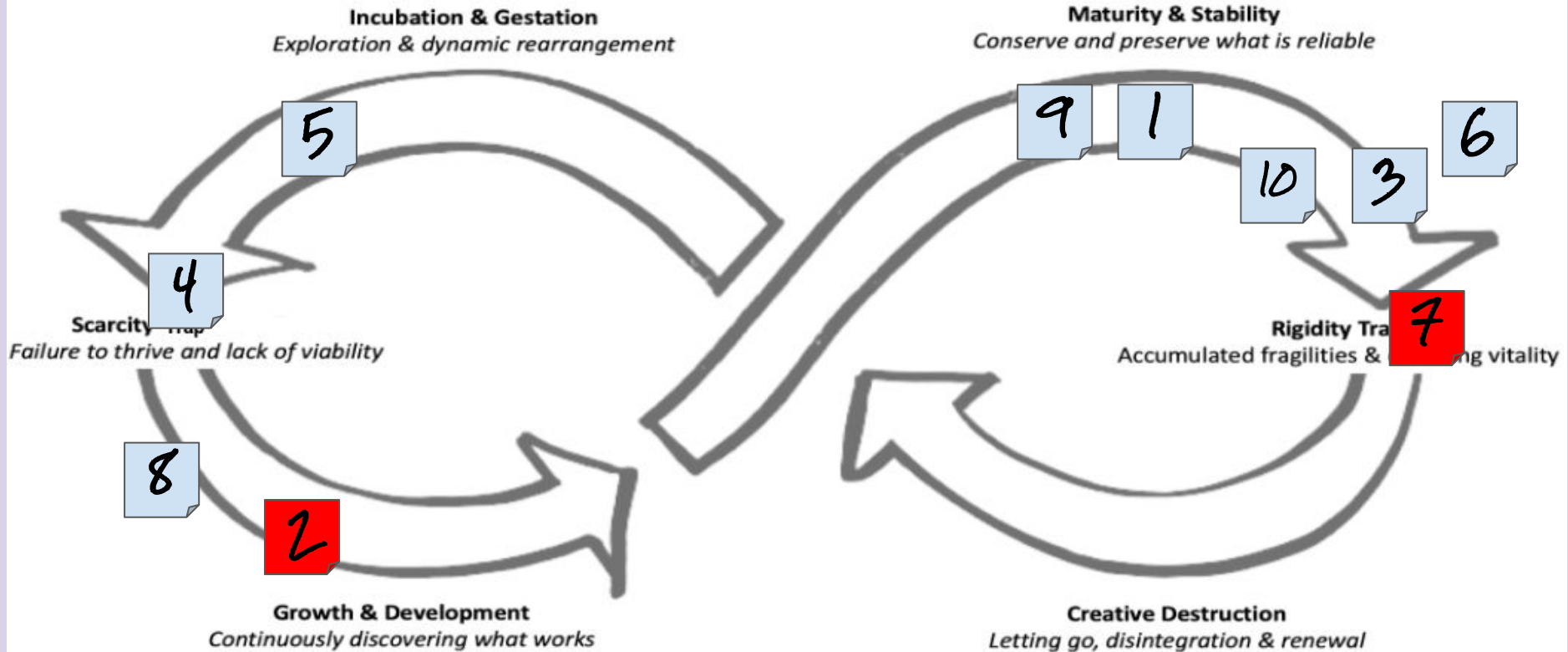
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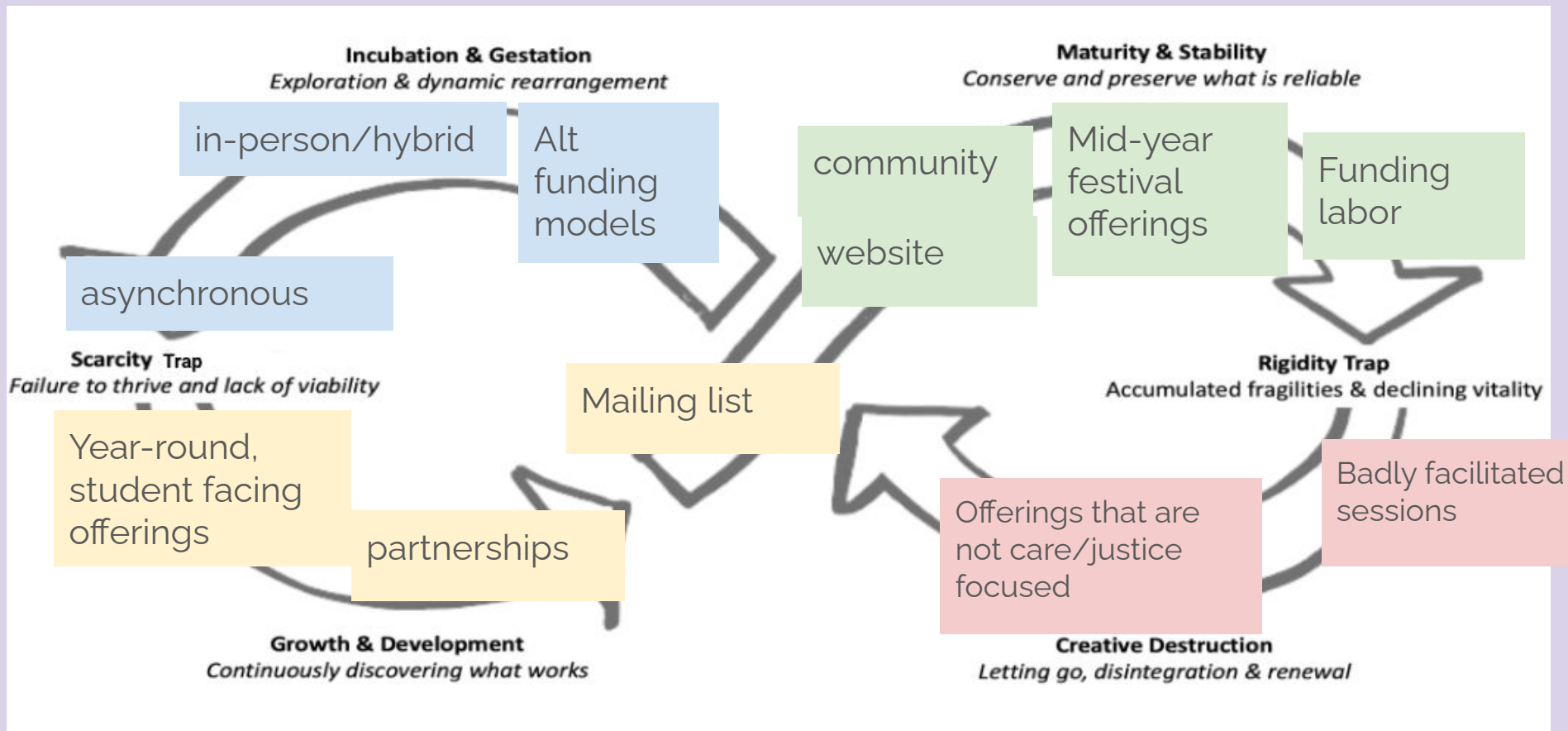
Name: joris





1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Name: Maha



Closing and What's Next

- May 12 Slowdown on Strategy Knotworking: <https://ls-slowdown.eventbrite.com>
- June 9 Speculations on... something: <https://lsspeculations.eventbrite.com>
- June 16 session on Knotworking: <https://ls-slowdown.eventbrite.com>